AI NATIVE ADVISORY · AI OPERATIONS

The Secure AI Workflow Checklist

For UK service businesses with 1–50 staff. Use this before you buy a tool, and again before a workflow touches client data. Work through it with the person who owns the process, not just the person who owns the technology.

Ten processes worth reviewing

Tick the ones that currently cost you time. Start with whichever produces the most lost revenue, not the most lost minutes.

- [ ] **Enquiry intake** — calls, forms, email and messaging arriving in one place, with nothing falling between them
- [ ] **First response and follow-up** — how quickly a new enquiry hears back, and what happens on the second attempt
- [ ] **Quoting and proposals** — building them, and chasing the ones not yet accepted
- [ ] **Client onboarding** — contracts, documents, welcome information, account setup
- [ ] **Booking and scheduling** — including reminders, rescheduling and no-shows
- [ ] **Document intake** — receiving, naming, filing and extracting from client documents
- [ ] **Meeting notes to actions** — who promised what, by when, and where that record lives
- [ ] **Reporting** — the weekly or monthly pack you rebuild by hand
- [ ] **Internal knowledge** — repetitive questions answered from someone's memory
- [ ] **Invoicing and credit control** — reminders, statements and reconciliation

Data-protection questions to ask

Answer all ten in writing before any workflow is switched on. "The supplier says it's compliant" is not an answer.

- [ ] **What personal data does the workflow touch?** Names, contact details, health information, financial information, or anything about a client's own customers?
- [ ] **Where does it go?** Which provider, which region, and does it leave the UK/EEA?
- [ ] **Is it used for training?** Confirm in writing that your data is not used to train or improve a model.
- [ ] **How long is it retained?** By the model provider, by the workflow tool, and in your own systems.
- [ ] **What is the lawful basis, and is it in your privacy notice?** Most service businesses will rely on legitimate interests or contract — either way, it should be written down.
- [ ] **Is there a data-processing agreement?** With each supplier that touches personal data on your behalf.

- [ ] **Who inside the business can see the data?** Access per workflow, not per company.
- [ ] **What is the deletion path?** If a client asks for erasure, can you actually find and remove the record?
- [ ] **What happens on vendor failure?** Export, ownership, and how you get your data out.
- [ ] **Are you processing special-category data?** Health, safeguarding, or legal detail needs a higher bar — and often a human-only path.

Human-review checkpoints

Write down the checkpoints, not the intention. Each line needs a named owner.

- [ ] **Outbound client communication** — anything sent to a client is approved by a person before it leaves, until the workflow has a track record and you decide otherwise
- [ ] **Pricing and commitments** — no quote, discount, delivery date or contractual term is generated and sent unreviewed
- [ ] **Professional judgement** — clinical, legal, financial or technical advice is drafted at most, never concluded by a model
- [ ] **Confidential or sensitive documents** — reviewed before summarisation, or excluded from the workflow entirely
- [ ] **Escalation route** — the named person a workflow hands to when it is unsure, with a response time
- [ ] **Kill switch** — who can switch the workflow off, and how, without waiting for a supplier

Owner of checkpoints: _____

Tool-selection criteria

Score each candidate against these. A tool that fails 3 or 4 will cost you more than it saves.

- [ ] **Fits the process you already run** — minimal change to how the team works today
- [ ] **Integrates with what you own** — your inbox, CRM, calendar and telephony, without a middleware project
- [ ] **Data terms you can live with** — no training on your data, clear retention, UK/EEA processing where required
- [ ] **Human-in-the-loop by default** — approval steps are built in, not bolted on
- [ ] **Auditable** — you can see what it did, to which record, and when
- [ ] **Portable** — you can export your data, prompts and configuration and leave
- [ ] **Priced per outcome you can measure** — not just per seat per month
- [ ] **Supportable by your team** — someone in the business can operate it after week four

Tools shortlisted: _____

Workflow test checklist

Run these before go-live, on real examples, with the team who will use it. Record pass or fail for each.

- [ ] **Happy path** — a normal, complete case goes through correctly five times in a row
- [ ] **Messy input** — typos, forwarded emails, a photo of a form, a message in the wrong channel
- [ ] **Missing information** — the workflow asks rather than invents. Check for fabricated details specifically
- [ ] **Duplicate and out-of-order events** — the same enquiry arriving twice does not produce two responses
- [ ] **Edge cases you already know about** — the difficult client, the unusual job, the exception only one person handles
- [ ] **Failure behaviour** — if a tool is down or a key expires, the process falls back to something that works and someone is told
- [ ] **Data check** — inspect what actually left your systems, not what the vendor says left
- [ ] **Handover test** — a team member who did not build it runs it end-to-end from the manual alone

Simple ROI template

Estimate honestly. If the numbers only work with optimistic inputs, the workflow is not ready.

Times this process runs per week	20
Minutes spent per run today	15
Share of that time saved (%)	50
Fully-loaded hourly cost of the person doing it (£)	25
Monthly tool cost (£)	60
One-off implementation cost (£)	3000

Hours saved per month	10.8 hrs
Value of time saved per month	£271
Monthly tool cost	£60
Net monthly benefit	**£211**
Payback on implementation	**14.2 months**

Assumes 4.33 weeks per month. Excludes revenue gained from faster response, which is usually the larger number and the harder one to prove. Use this to sanity-check a decision, not to forecast a return.

If you want a second opinion on your answers

We run a focused **AI Workflow Audit** for UK service businesses: current-state process map, opportunity assessment, prioritised roadmap, data and risk review, 90-day plan and a business case with estimated savings. Book an audit or email hello@ainativeorganisations.com.